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Theological Method

The overall aim of this book has been the development of theological foundations, a task conceived as a specialization or stage within a functionally differentiated and collaborative theological method. However, to this point, we have said little to explain the nature of that theological method, though it has functioned throughout this book. Elements of this method appear in (later) chapters where we distinguish the task of foundations from doctrines and systematics. Now it is time to make that method more explicit. Our method distinguishes eight interrelated theological tasks, each of which makes a distinct contribution to the theological project. Following the terminology of Bernard Lonergan, we call these tasks *functional specialties*.¹ The tasks are *functional*, that is, they break the overall project of theology into distinctive steps or stages; and so the *specialties* do not divide up theology into themes or subject areas, or sources and resources, but into a series of interlocking stages that move theology from data to results to the communication of those results. Developing theological foundations marks a distinct stage or specialty within this process.

1. See Lonergan, *Method*.

As we have emphasized from the beginning, our theological foundations are grounded in conversion, as religious, moral, intellectual, and psychic. These conversions tell us something about the subjectivity of the theologian. This, in turn, will help us lay out the theological method implicit in our foundations.

Conversion and the Transcendental Imperatives

We begin with *religious conversion*. We spoke in chapter 2 of this in terms of falling in love unrestrictedly so that we see the world through the eyes of love. We noted how St. Paul spoke of God's love poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit given to us (Rom. 5:5), and described the Spirit's residence in us by pointing to the fruits: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, gentleness, faithfulness, and self-control (Gal. 5:22). These expressions capture something of the reality we mean by religious conversion and its impact on our lives. The transcendental imperative that expresses this conversion is "Be in love." We are called to "Be in Love" at the natural level of family, friends, and lovers, but even more so with the One who is the source of everything that is, of all meaning, truth, and goodness in our lives. However, as with all fallings in love, it is not so much an achievement as a gift and invitation; not something we generate ourselves, rather something that overtakes us, seduces us, envelops us.

Moral conversion entails a shift in our decision making from mere satisfactions to genuine values. In chapter 3 we recalled the story of St. Ignatius of Loyola who learned through his own experience of reading the lives of the saints how to discriminate between fleeting satisfactions and genuine values and then committed himself to those values. Similarly, St. Augustine, while converted religiously, struggled with his moral conversion to sexual continence, eventually

to embrace this as well. The transcendental imperative that expresses this conversion is “Be responsible.” We are all called to “Be responsible,” to act responsibly by basing our decisions on genuine values, to take responsibility for our own moral living, not to just flow with the crowd, but to take responsibility for ourselves, for others, and for the world, in promoting genuine flourishing in human history.

More difficult and less common is *intellectual conversion*. This has a twofold aspect: the appropriation of our own knowing processes grounded in intelligence and reason; and the alignment of our criteria for reality with our processes of knowing. Again, in chapter 4, we illustrated this process of conversion in the life of St. Augustine as he turned from thinking about God as somehow extended in space and time to thinking of God as “Truth.” Intellectual conversion means rejecting the persistent myth that reality is “already-out-there-now,” to be apprehended by taking a good look. It means rather that we think of the real as the objective of intelligent and reasonable questioning. We are called to bring intelligence and reason to bear in grasping reality, to persist in asking the basic questions, “What is it?” (questions for intelligence) and “Is it so?” (questions for reasonable judgment) until we address all the relevant questions and thus attain reality, truth, and being. The imperatives that express this conversion are: “Be intelligent” and “Be reasonable.”

Finally, most difficult and perhaps least common is *psychic conversion*. Psychic conversion asks us to attend to what attracts us and holds out attention. It asks us to attend to beauty. Are we attracted to the beauty of genuine meaning, truth, and goodness, or are we distracted with “many things”? The imperative that expresses this is “Be attentive,” attentive to the object of our attention, to the data, but also to our own attentiveness, to ask to what it is that we are attracted,

what holds our attention, so that we might better align ourselves to meaning, truth, and genuine value.

These imperatives, Be attentive, Be intelligent, Be reasonable, Be responsible, and Be in love, provide us with the structure of the basic operations and orientations of human consciousness. We begin with the data to which we attend; we ask questions for intelligence, “What is it?,” so as to discover the meaning of the data. We then have an insight, formulate an hypothesis, and this raises the critical question, “Is it so?,” with its demand for reasons, so that we can come to an informed judgment about the meaning of the data. Finally the questions arise, “What are we to do?” “What decisions flow from this judgment and how are we to respond properly, to be responsible in the current situation?” The movement from data to decision entails a cumulative process structured by questions and answers. This process relies on and reveals our inner orientation to meaning, truth, and goodness. The final imperative, Be in love, discloses our deepest and most fundamental orientation, the wellspring of all our other conscious processes, the *apex animae* (the peak of the soul). Do our questions and answers come from a place of hardness of heart, of self-reliance and self-assertion? Or do they come from a heart of flesh, of graciously receiving our lives, our existence, as gift from the source of all meaning, truth, and goodness? This basic orientation has a profound effect on all our conscious operations.

How then does this structure relate to the theological task? We might begin by reflecting on more traditional approaches at least within a Catholic context. A student in the preconciliar church would begin theological preparation with courses in philosophy, which may (or may not) catalyze some type of intellectual conversion. Religious and moral conversion were more or less taken for granted, perhaps an issue for spiritual formation rather than theological formulation and explication, so the student moved on,

after a course in fundamental theology/apologetics, to a study of the basic religious and moral doctrines that were part of the church's heritage. If lucky, the student may have studied not only the doctrines (proven by reason, Scripture, and authority), but what doctrines might mean and how they might systematically relate to one another, before hitting courses concerned with their pastoral implementation and communication, preaching, catechesis, moral guidance and pastoral care, according to the mind of the church.

We might roughly align these with the imperatives as follows. Courses in fundamental theology/apologetics are in some sense taking *responsibility* for the further theological tasks to come, laying out foundations through a consideration of sources (scripture, tradition, authority, reason) and their relative authority in preparation for the religious and moral doctrines which form the church's heritage. The study of doctrines presents the tradition's *reasoned* judgments of religious and moral truths while systematics sought to *intelligently* understand the meaning of these doctrines and their relationship to one another, always aware that in dealing with religious mysteries, such understanding could never be exhausted. Finally, in considering the pastoral implementation and communication of the church's doctrines and their meanings, one must be *attentive* to the concrete particularities of the recipients, as they are not abstractions but living, breathing human beings, who live in a particular social and cultural setting. While this might seem somewhat forced, this approach basically describes the type of theological education that occurred within Catholic tradition prior to Vatican II.²

The other thing to note here is that the movement through the theological disciplines is the opposite to that of the natural movement

2. Of course, much of this structure was put aside post-Vatican II when courses began to incorporate aspects of historical consciousness into theological studies.

we posited above, from attention to intelligence, reasonableness, and then responsibility. This raises the obvious question, how did we get to that level of responsibility in the first place? More concretely, this question was posed in terms of the emergence of historical consciousness and the historical development of doctrine. If doctrines have histories, which we can trace in detail through all their tortuous debates, in what sense do they hold our allegiance? The traditional approach started, after a foray into apologetics, with what is ontologically prior (*priora quoad se*), in the basic judgments of Christian revelation, rather than what we first encounter, the *intersubjective, artistic, symbolic* carriers of revelatory meanings experienced as data. With the emergence of historical consciousness, theological scholars began to read the traditional sources of theology not as authoritative documents carrying meanings and values of the tradition, but simply as historical documents to be read and understood as products of their place and time. Theology discovered *critical historical method*. In itself, this was a theological revolution that threatened to relativize what had always been taken as absolute. It created a theological problem because it appeared to involve two sources of truth, one known through historical investigation, the other through revelation and the articles of faith, where the two sources may or may not coincide.

Much of the history of twentieth century theology has been about the encounter of traditional theological approaches with modern critical historical method. Its impact was first felt in relation to Scriptural studies, then to patristic and doctrinal studies. Joseph Ratzinger has identified as a central problem for theology the need to find “a better synthesis between historical and theological methods, between higher criticism and church doctrine.” Further, “a truly pervasive understanding of this whole problem has yet to be found which takes into account both the undeniable insights uncovered

by historical method, while at the same time overcoming its limitations.”³ Following the work of Lonergan, what we propose in terms of theological method is one way of seeking to address this challenge.

Transcendental Imperatives and Functional Specialties

We have noted above the ways in which a more traditional approach to theology incorporates the transcendental imperatives (be responsible, be reasonable, be intelligent, and be attentive) by moving from fundamental theology to doctrines, systematics, and then finally to concrete applications to the life of the church. However, we can also envisage a reversal of the imperatives as applied to the data of revelation entering into and shaping human history. Taken together, these processes give us an eightfold differentiation of theological tasks. Following Lonergan, we call these tasks “functional specialties.” The following table best illustrates these:

Imperatives	Positive phase	Normative phase
Be responsible	Dialectics	Foundations
Be reasonable	History	Doctrines
Be intelligent	Interpretation	Systematics
Be attentive	Research	Communications

Traditional theology was very strong in relation to what we call the normative phase of theology, with a strong emphasis on doctrine,

3. Joseph Ratzinger, “Foundations and Approaches of Biblical Exegesis,” *Origins* 17, no. 35 (1988): 593, 595–602 (596). For Ratzinger, the limitations of critical historical method lay in its neglect of the dogmatic tradition, as exercising some control as to its outcomes. Similarly Lonergan commented: “the whole problem in modern theology, Protestant and Catholic, is the introduction of historical scholarship.” Quoted in Frederick E. Crowe, *Developing the Lonergan Legacy: Historical, Theoretical and Existential Themes*, ed. Michael Vertin (Toronto: University of Toronto, 2004), 79.

its understanding, and applications. The first, positive phase, which arises with autonomy in relation to the normative phase, encompasses the movement from attending to the original data (research), intelligently reading it in context (interpretation), and constructing an historical narrative that accounts for its meaning and significance (history). Such historical narratives often disagree, and do so in quite fundamental ways, so theologians must sort out and adjudicate the differences (dialectics). This process then establishes a background and launching pad for the normative phase. In fact, we used this strategy in chapter 1 where we identified dialectical differences among various theological writings and the need to resolve them. Now, we shall consider each of the specialties in more detail and how they relate to one another and to the theologian's ongoing conversion.

Research

Research is the starting point for any theological task, but here the term has a more precise delineation. It is concerned with our attentiveness to the data. This most basic form of research is concerned with the accuracy of the data, the sort of work we find in Scripture studies where scholars seek to ensure that we have an accurate manuscript for the Bible, usually referred to as textual criticism. Of course, this extends to all other texts, patristic, medieval, and modern. Have we got an accurate text?⁴ Are we starting with accurate data?⁵ This is often meticulous and detailed work requiring

4. Here, we focus on texts as it is the most common issue for theology, but we could include archaeology, numismatics (coins), monuments, ancient cartography, and so on, as data of interest for their historical implications.

5. As Paul Maas notes, "We have no autograph manuscripts of the Greek and Roman classical writers and no copies which have been collated with the originals; the manuscripts we possess derive from the originals through an unknown number of intermediate copies, and are consequently of questionable trustworthiness. The business of textual criticism is to produce

specialized knowledge of ancient manuscripts, their production, reproduction, and storage methods, and so on. A good example of this type of work would be the efforts to decide on the accuracy of the text of John's account of the adulterous woman (John 7:53–8:11), which occurs in some manuscripts but not others. Generally, scholars who work in this field develop a kitbag of methods for making decisions about which text is accurate. Such *lectio difficilior*, a more difficult reading, is preferred because a scribe is more likely to smooth out difficulties than introduce them.⁶ All this is very familiar territory for scholars working in the field. Most historical and systematic theologians, however, take this work for granted as part of the scholarly background for their overall projects.

While the focus above has been on texts, the same issues arise in relation to various fields of data. These fields may include archaeology, numismatics (coins), monuments, ancient cartography, or data about social practices, both ancient and modern, or even data on religious experiences. In each case, the functional specialty of research raises questions about the accuracy of the data. While theology has traditionally been concerned with this aspect in relation to traditional sources such as Scripture, church documents, and the texts of major figures from the past, increasingly other data, particularly in relation to the social sciences, are becoming important in theological studies.

However, as we have noted, to be attentive is also to focus on our own attentiveness. Why do we choose this data over all other available data? What is it about this data that captures and holds our attention? What draws us into this particular study? This can be taken broadly—Why do I study Christian history and tradition rather than

a text as close as possible to the original (*constitutio textus*).” Maas, *Textual Criticism* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1958), 1.

6. See, for example, Bruce M. Metzger and Bart D. Ehrman, *The Text of the New Testament: Its Transmission, Corruption, and Restoration* (Oxford: Oxford University, 2005).

Buddhism?—or it may be taken more narrowly—Why do I study St. Paul rather than the Gospels, Augustine rather than Gregory of Nyssa, Aquinas rather than Bonaventure, Luther rather than Calvin? Are my choices themselves part of my own responsiveness to God's call mediated through the tradition's many carriers of meaning (such as texts and persons)? This may not be the place to address such questions at length, but inevitably, wherever we start, such questions—related as they are to our psychic, religious, moral, and intellectual conversion—are important to our theological engagement.

Interpretation

Of course, accurate texts are important, but without the active engagement of a skilled interpreter, they remain just “black marks on white paper.” *Interpretation* asks about the meaning of the text as intended by the author and as heard by the intended audience. To do so accurately requires asking various questions. What is the literary form of the text? Is the text poetic, mythic, legendary? To misread the literary form will be to misread the text, as when some people read Genesis as if it were a scientific treatise. What rhetorical tropes does the author deploy, that may have been familiar to the audience, but are no longer familiar to us? If the text is an historical narrative, how has the author constructed that narrative, what sources have been utilized, what message is conveyed through the author's structuring of the narrative, and so on? All these are the familiar approaches of modern Scripture scholarship—form criticism, narrative criticism, rhetorical criticism, and so on. They require detailed knowledge of the languages of the text, the culture and literature of the era in which it was written, the literary sources available to the author, and so on. And the technique will differ with the literary form involved. More

technical texts such as the *Summa Theologiae* or documents produced by church councils require a different approach than what exegetes use for the literary forms of the New Testament.

The task of interpretation orients us to the text's meaning as intended by the author and as heard by the intended audience.⁷ This is a relatively delineated task leading to the not uncommon criticism that biblical scholars are "good at telling us what the text meant, but not what it means for us today." Of course, this is a valid and important issue, but addressing it requires further work. One must take into account the way in which the text has been received within the tradition, how the tradition has found in the text divine meaning and value, and expressed that meaning and value in its teachings (doctrines, systematics). Then one must make the transition through a reading of the contemporary setting in all its present complexity, in an attempt to bring the text into dialogue with that setting. This is a profoundly creative and even artistic task. It may be quite premature to think one can move directly from the original meaning of the text to the meaning the text now has for us, without these intervening tasks. On the other hand, these questions highlight that the theological task is not complete with interpretations of the text in its original context, but we must move on to the next task which links texts and their authors into a historical narrative.

We can see the emergence of this specialty in the shifting approaches to reading the Gospels. In a precritical worldview, people tend to read the Gospels as if they offer diaries of the life of Jesus, telling us what Jesus did on a day-to-day basis. One of the first aims of modern biblical criticism was to ask, What really happened?, and a large amount of scholarly activity aimed at getting to the

7. For a defense of this stance from a biblical scholar, see Ben F. Meyer, *Reality and Illusion in New Testament Scholarship: A Primer in Critical Realist Hermeneutics* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical, 1994).

history *behind* the narrative.⁸ This was the dominance of historical criticism. However, biblical scholars began to consider a question that precedes the historical question, which is the literary question. And so now exegetes focus more on narrative criticism, treating the Gospel as a literary construct where the author shapes the narrative with particular ends in mind. Of course, this does not devalue the historical question, but rather seeks the answer to that question through the mediation of interpreting the text as a literary unit.

History

We can view texts as complete units with their own formal meaning, as constructed by their authors and then the task is one of interpretation. However, we can also view a text as part of a historical flow of texts, persons, and events. Then, the text becomes an historical marker, part of the dynamic process of *history*. Texts refer to this process in two possible ways: as records of events within the process of history, and as themselves elements within that process. The specialty of history constructs a narrative of the events recorded and of the texts that record those events. It seeks to uncover the dynamics of the process of history. It does not find immediate access to events in past records, but must steer its way through multiple accounts and sources in order to shed light on those events, to uncover what is moving forward in history. It is *critical* history.

We have already discussed one application of the specialty of history, that is, as witnessed in the quest for the historical Jesus. While the initial attempts tended to bypass the literary question, the most recent efforts take the literary issue into their full consideration. Still, the aim is the same, namely, to recreate, through the events

8. This was particularly evident in the various quests for the historical Jesus. See, for example, Gregory W. Dawes, *The Historical Jesus Quest: Landmarks in the Search for the Jesus of History* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 2000).

as narrated, something of the actual history of Jesus. One notable attempt is the multivolume work by John Meier, *A Marginal Jew*. As with the work of text criticism, those who undertake this reconstruction have developed a kitbag of tools, or criteria of authenticity, in attempts to locate the genuineness of sayings and events as narrated in the Gospel.⁹ Of course, different authors develop different criteria and even when they use the same criteria, they may come up with quite different answers. The question then arises, how do we give an account of these divergent positions? Is it just that some are better at this type of work than others? Or perhaps the type of objectivity being sought is a myth? To address these questions a further task in the theological project needs to be undertaken. However, before we do that we should note other possible examples of the specialty of history:

- There can be a developing movement within the history of the church, such as the consolidation of certain doctrinal positions. For example, the early church's thinking on the divinity of Jesus underwent significant development from the creation of the New Testament texts to the councils of Nicaea and Constantinople.¹⁰ Certain attitudes and ways of speaking and acting were "moving forward" in this process. Some positions were abandoned; others were refined or highlighted, until a stable point was reached and a conclusion was eventually consolidated. Such processes are more conflictual than linear, and since the historian may have an interest

9. See, for example, the criteria developed in Meier, *A Marginal Jew: Rethinking the Historical Jesus*, 1, 167–95. Also Meyer, *The Aims of Jesus*, 76–94.

10. See, for example, the accounts in the following works: Bernard J. F. Lonergan, *The Way to Nicaea: the Dialectical Development of Trinitarian Theology*, trans. Conn O'Donovan (London: Darton, Longman, and Todd, 1976); John Behr, *The Way to Nicaea* (Crestwood, NY: St. Vladimir's Seminary, 2001); and the magisterial Lewis Ayres, *Nicaea and its Legacy: An Approach to Fourth-Century Trinitarian Theology* (Oxford: Oxford University, 2004), for the history of reception and consolidation.

in the conflict, the narrative of the process becomes an evaluation: Is this development good or bad? Is it progress or decline? Again, the inquiry anticipates a further step.

- Development may also occur in the thinking of a particular individual, and historians may consider this as a subset of the above process. On a complex issue, such as the interrelationship of grace and human freedom, there may be a trajectory of thought within the work of a particular thinker.¹¹ Earlier insights give way to later ones, while dead ends are left behind as new pathways open up for development. It would then be wrong to try to interpret later writings within the framework of earlier positions, which have been superseded. To do such an account well requires not only a thorough knowledge of the thinker, but also of the issue that occupies his or her attention.¹²

Coda on Critical Historical Method

The three specialties of research, interpretation, and history taken together constitute what theologians generally refer to as *critical historical method*. As a method, it is not specific to theology and could be applied to any received text in, say, literature, history, science or philosophy. What then makes these tasks theological? An easy answer would be that what makes these tasks theological is the subject matter. So instead of applying these tasks to Homer's *Iliad*, we use them to understand Mark's Gospel. However, more than this is at issue. These steps concern the use of our natural human reasoning in dealing with data, any data, even that of a religious tradition.

11. See, for example, Bernard J. F. Lonergan, *Grace and Freedom: Operative Grace in the Thought of St. Thomas Aquinas*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, vol. 1, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto, 2000).

12. Just as to write a history of mathematics one should be a pretty good mathematician oneself. Otherwise one cannot appreciate the nature and significance of the developments that occur.

To exclude them from theology would be to exclude reason itself, seeking refuge in some faith-filled but unthinking fideistic realm. These steps do not presuppose faith in the one undertaking them, but neither do they exclude faith; nor should they be viewed as hostile to faith. Does faith then make any difference to the process and to the outcomes? Raising such a question may lead us to consider questions of objectivity. Does the faith stance of the theologian make them any the less objective than a “detached” nonreligious enquirer? Or does faith open the investigator up to realities that the nonreligious enquirer is closed off to? Indeed, if the data is about the inbreaking of divine meaning and value into human history, then nonreligious researchers may find themselves “tone deaf” to the religious depths of the material, to its divine meanings and values. In the terms of the present work, religious conversion provides a more profound orientation to meaning, truth, and goodness because it opens up the enquirer to the religious depths of the data. On the other hand, if one systematically rejects the very possibility of such an inbreaking of divine meaning and value, one may be cutting oneself off from truth. The only guarantor of objectivity is one’s fidelity to the precepts: Be attentive, Be intelligent, Be reasonable, Be attentive, and Be in love.

Dialectics

We have already noted that the outcomes of critical historical method are not uniform. This is very evident when we turn to critical historical studies of the life of Jesus. Many of the divergences in outcomes lie not in the data, but in the presuppositions of the researchers attending to the data. Of course, some differences in the outcomes of critical history may be complementary, the result of differing perspectives in the investigators or the inclusion of new data shedding light on the question. This provides us with a fuller account and can be welcomed. However, some differences are dialectical

oppositions, emerging from opposed horizons; what one says is true, the other says is false; what one says is good, the other finds wicked; what one judges to be from God, the other finds merely human or worse, evidence for the devil.¹³ The researcher may have assumptions about how or whether God acts in history, or have notions of objectivity as “taking a good look,” and so on. The presence or absence of religious, moral, intellectual, and psychic conversions forms part of the background of the researcher and affects the way the data is handled. However, the first task is to attend to the divergent outcomes provided by critical historical method, to identify the patterns that may be present within this divergence, and so raise the question as to the sources of this divergence within the subject. This brings us to the next specialty, *dialectics*.

The specialty of dialectics is most clearly in evidence in the work of liberation and feminist theology. Both these approaches remind us that the theologian’s horizon influences the outcome of theology. If a theologian enjoys some of the privileges of power and wealth, then this can introduce unintended distortions or scotomas into their readings of the documents and traditions of the past. What is required is a preferential option for the poor and marginalized to read history from the underside, from the perspective of history’s victims.¹⁴ Feminist theologians remind us that patriarchy becomes a lens through which we read Christian tradition. Sexism is a sin from which we require a conversion in order to deal more adequately with both the documents of the past and the present institutional context.¹⁵ Both these theological approaches not only highlight the significance of dialectically divergent horizons operating with the theologian, they also point to the resolution of this divergence in a process of

13. For example, the Pharisees found in Jesus’ miracles signs of the devil. See Mark 3:20–30.

14. See the seminal work in liberation theology, Gutiérrez, *A Theology of Liberation*.

15. See works such as Elisabeth Schüssler Fiorenza, *But She Said: Feminist Practices of Biblical Interpretation* (Boston: Beacon, 1992); Ruether, *Sexism and God-Talk*.

conversion within the theologian. In this instance, one could well argue that the underlying issue is one of moral conversion, or at least a dimension of moral conversion. Both involve a movement from mere satisfactions offered by power and privilege toward genuine value, the genuine value of the other, either the poor or women systematically excluded from power and privilege.

Dialectics then asks a question of the theologian: Where do I stand? In the face of these dialectically opposed horizons that emerge in our dialectical analysis of the outcomes of the first three functional specialties, where do I stand? To which horizon will I hitch my wagon? Is my present horizon challenged to enlarge, or perhaps be radically restructured on fundamental questions of truth, meaning, value, beauty and even God? Dialectics raises the question of *conversion* in its various modalities: religious, moral, intellectual, and psychic. This in fact takes us back to chapter 1 where we raised issues of divergence within theological stances, the significance of those divergences and the ways they might be resolved. This then leads us to the functional specialty of the present work.

Foundations

If dialectics raises the question of conversion, *foundations* thematizes conversion as the horizon for the second, normative phase of theology. With foundations, the theologian becomes the object of theological concern. Am I converted toward the source of all meaning, truth, and goodness (religious conversion)? Do I make my decisions on the basis of genuine values or mere satisfactions (moral conversion)? Have I overcome, or even recognized the existence of, the persistent myth that knowing is a matter of taking a good look, that reality is already out there now to be seen, and objectivity consists in seeing what is there to be seen and not seeing what is

not there to be seen (intellectual conversion)? Am I oriented toward beauty as a participation in the truly meaningful, the truly real, the truly good, and truly holy (psychic conversion)?

Of course, people can engage in theology without attending to these questions, but to that extent their theology is likely to fall short of the demands to be attentive, intelligent, reasonable, responsible, and in love with God. These demands are constitutive of human authenticity, and all that the conversions identified above do is to make these demands explicit and foundational for the theological task. Nonetheless, we all fall short of these demands to some extent as Lonergan reminds us: authenticity is ever a withdrawal from inauthenticity.¹⁶ However, the transcendental precepts and the conversions that thematize them present an account of “faith and reason” as at the heart of the theological project, with no diminution of faith, nor any truncation of reason.

Of course, many postmodern voices insist on anti-foundationalist strategies that reject any conception of foundations as misleading and even violent. There is only an ongoing task of building and knocking down and starting over again, doing the best we can as authentically as we can. While the postmodern emphasis on authenticity is to be welcomed, its rejection of foundations and the possibility of objectivity in theology is itself the product of mistaken positions on knowing, objectivity, and reality.¹⁷ On the foundations developed above, objectivity is itself the fruit of authenticity, conceived as fidelity to the transcendental precepts.¹⁸ Any attempt to deny the authenticity of such precepts will inevitably call us to be *attentive*

16. Lonergan, *Method*, 110.

17. See the thorough discussion in Frederick G. Lawrence, “The Fragility of Consciousness: Lonergan and the Postmodern Concern for the Other,” *Theological Studies* 54 no. 1 (1993): 55–94. Also on the importance of the emergence of authenticity in the present era see Taylor, *A Secular Age*.

18. Lonergan, *Method*, 292.

to certain data, to understand it *intelligently*, to come to a *reasonable* judgment concerning that data and our understanding of it, and to then act *responsibly* in the light of that judgment. Such an argument would be performatively self-refuting.

The other task of foundations is to provide us with a language with which to undertake theology, that is, a set of categories for raising and answering theological questions, where the meaning of those categories is set by the horizon of the converted theologian. Of course, theologians may speak of meaning, truth, goodness, and beauty, but the horizons from which they operate may or may not be morally, intellectually and psychically converted. To that extent, while they are using the same words, the meanings these words have within those horizons will be very different. For example, Tertullian, Origen, and Athanasius all spoke of the Father and the Son as being of one substance/*homoousios*. However, for Tertullian substance meant “material stuff,” shaped by his adherence to Stoic materialism; for Origen substance meant some sort of Platonic idea; while for Athanasius it meant “what is true of the Father is true of the Son, except the Father is not the Son.” For Athanasius the real (substance) is aligned with true judgment, marking the beginnings of intellectual conversion. And so in the present work, the conversions have established the meaning of categories such as God, value, a hierarchical and normative scale of values, being, real, truth, objectivity, and beauty. This is of course only the beginning of the foundational task, but it helps establish the basic horizon that will generate all genuine categories for future theological work.

Doctrines

If foundations seek to be responsible in explicating the horizon of the theologian, the functional specialty of *doctrines* seeks to be reasonable

in making judgments of truth and value that emerge from those foundations. Primary among these will be judgments of religious truth that emerge from religious conversion in interaction with the data of the religious tradition, though the manner of their expression will be shaped by the presence or absence of moral, intellectual, and psychic conversion in those who formulated them. Religious conversions normally occur within the context of a particular religious tradition, which itself is constituted by its adherence to a set of judgments of truth (doctrines as cognitional meaning) made in the past that establish its identity as an historical community (doctrines as constitutive meaning). Immediately then, the theologian may be confronted with a tension between her own personal judgments made on the basis of her own theological foundations, and those of the historical community which has mediated the experience of religious conversion to her. This raises the question not only of the authenticity of the theologian, but also of the authenticity of the tradition the theologian has received. Such a question pushes us back to issues of dialectics (Can she discern a pattern in the differences?) and foundations (Where does she stand?). It may be that the theologian's conversion is incomplete, that her authenticity is still a work in progress. Or it may be that the religious judgment of the tradition is expressed inadequately because couched in inadequate moral, intellectual or psychic conversions. The theologian may then have the task of expressing either a different (and thus corrective) religious truth or the same religious truth in a way that harmonizes more with moral, intellectual, and psychic conversions. A third possibility is that of the inauthenticity of the tradition itself, that its religious judgments are flawed and in need of correction. Then the task of the theologian is the reforming of the tradition itself.¹⁹

In the Christian tradition, the major religious judgments of the

19. We need look no further than the Reformation for an instance where some theologians, notably

tradition have been on God as Trinity,²⁰ the person of Christ,²¹ and on grace and sin.²² These judgments focus on the way in which the events of the New Testament, the mission, death, and resurrection of Jesus, have mediated a profound religious conversion in those who knew him and in the ongoing life of the church.²³ A second level of judgments deals with the ongoing life of the community itself, its sacramental and moral life, its canonical writings, its institutions and structures.²⁴ A third level of judgments deals with the ways in which the church constitutes itself through this process of making such judgments, when it begins to reflect on its own performance as an historical community making substantive judgments on doctrinal matters.²⁵ This presents us with a doctrinal hierarchy, not of truth but of importance or centrality to the core of revelation.²⁶ Significantly, over history, the more we move through these levels, the more likely disputation will occur, leading to schism within the broader church.

We have already discussed in chapter 7 on revelation questions concerning the permanency of doctrines and doctrinal development. Here we shall simply repeat that one of the greatest challenges facing

Luther and Calvin, questioned the authenticity of the judgments of the Christian tradition as then received, particularly on questions of sin and grace.

20. The Councils of Nicaea (325 CE) and Constantinople (381 CE), in particular.

21. The Councils of Ephesus (431 CE) and Chalcedon (451 CE), in particular.

22. More so in the West than in the East, with the Councils of Carthage and Orange. These were subject to further debate and disputation in the Reformation and Counter-Reformation.

23. As is often pointed out we have no formally declared doctrines on this most foundational event itself. It is so foundational that to question it immediately marks a break with the tradition itself.

24. Most evidently at the Council of Trent, though it was also concerned with ongoing issues on grace and sin as raised by the Reformers.

25. Most evident at Vatican I on papal infallibility and Vatican II's attempts to nuance Vatican I in *Lumen Gentium*.

26. Hence Vatican II talks of a hierarchy of truths within the context of ecumenism: "When comparing doctrines with one another, they [theologians] should remember that in Catholic doctrine there exists a 'hierarchy' of truths, since they vary in their relation to the fundamental Christian faith" (*Unitatis Redintegratio*, n. 11). Second Vatican Council Decree on Ecumenism, *Unitatis Redintegratio*, n. 11, available at http://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_decree_19641121_unitatis-redintegratio_en.html (accessed October 2, 2014).

the whole notion of doctrine at the moment is finding a way through the tensions of a permanently valid truth affirmed in doctrines and the impact of historical consciousness on our understanding of doctrinal development. Many of these tensions arise out of questions of intellectual conversion, over questions of truth and objectivity. Without a firm grounding in intellectual conversion, the distinction between doctrines and systematics breaks down, doctrines appear as just one theological option among many, and the distinctive roles of theologians and church authorities become lost. As A. N. Williams notes of contemporary theological work, for example, “the terms ‘systematic theology’, ‘Christian doctrine’ and ‘dogmatics’ have no uniformly established usage and a preference for one or the other is often arbitrary.”²⁷ Similarly, Nicholas Healy refers to “official systematic theology” as “the form of theological inquiry and production that has some authority over other forms, or . . . at least claims or assumes that authority.”²⁸ This stands in contrast with what he calls “professional systematic theology” carried out in the academy or university, which “is necessarily diverse in its methods, starting points and agendas, and should not be restricted by the method, starting point and agenda of official theology.”²⁹ Our position, however, which emerges out of intellectual conversion, draws a sharp distinction between the task of doctrines and that of systematics, to which we now turn.

Systematics

The functional specialty of *systematics* is best expressed by the classical ideal of “faith seeking understanding.” As an activity that draws

27. A. N. Williams, “What Is Systematic Theology?,” *International Journal of Systematic Theology* 11, no. 1 (2009): 40–55 (41).

28. Nicholas M. Healy, “What is Systematic Theology?,” *International Journal of Systematic Theology* 11, no. 1 (2009): 24–39 (27).

29. *Ibid.*, 38.

upon and is grounded in faith, systematics presumes the outcomes of both foundations and doctrines as its basic normative content. The judgments of doctrines are true, but remain judgments concerning divine meaning and value, and hence beyond human comprehension. They are mysteries in the sense, not of being unintelligible, but of being so full of meaning as to be inexhaustible for human understanding. There is a richness of meaning present in these doctrines that we can never cease to better understand. The task of systematics is to work toward an understanding of these mysteries in a coherent and comprehensive way, bringing the whole into a unified intelligible framework.

However, given that we are not able to fully understand the mysteries of faith, how shall we go about this task? Here the teaching of Vatican I is instructive:

Now reason, if it is enlightened by faith, does indeed when it seeks persistently, piously and soberly, achieve by God's gift, some understanding, and that most profitable, of the mysteries, whether by analogy from what it knows naturally, or from the connexion of these mysteries with one another and with the final end of humanity; but reason is never rendered capable of penetrating these mysteries in the way in which it penetrates those truths which form its proper object. For the divine mysteries, by their very nature, so surpass the created understanding that, even when a revelation has been given and accepted by faith, they remain covered by the veil of that same faith and wrapped as it were, in a certain obscurity, as long as in this mortal life 'we are away from the Lord, for we walk by faith, and not by sight' [2 Cor. 5:6f].³⁰

Here, the council puts forward two paths for reaching some level of understanding of the mysteries expressed in doctrines. The first is through an "analogy from what it knows naturally." We can witness

30. Vatican I Dogmatic Constitution, *Dei Filius*, chapter 4, translation from Norman P. Tanner, *Decrees of the Ecumenical Councils*, 2 vols. (London/Washington, DC: Sheed & Ward/Georgetown University, 1990), 2:808.

this at work in the *Summa Theologiae* 1.27.1 where Aquinas asks whether there are processions in God. This is a question calling for a judgment, a yes or a no. As such, Aquinas settles the matter in the affirmative by drawing on the authority of Scripture and church doctrines. However, he does not leave the matter there because, though the question has been answered, without some understanding, the mind would not be properly nourished; without understanding, however limited, the doctrine will appear as just an arbitrary fact about God to be assented to, but unrelated to anything else and hence in the end will appear meaningless. Hence, he immediately seeks out an analogy for the divine procession, based on the procession within the human mind of a concept from an act of understanding. This procession can be naturally known, though not without difficulty. Of course, there are dissimilarities involved as well, because the procession of a concept from an act of understanding in us does not produce a distinct person, but there is enough of a similarity for us to get some handle on what a procession might mean in God. This is a paradigmatic example of the use of analogy.

While analogy attempts to provide us with some understanding of a mystery of faith, the council proposed the second approach of uncovering “the connexion of these mysteries with one another and with the final end of humanity.” In more contemporary parlance, this task concerns the internal coherence of Christian faith. It seeks the intelligible connections among the different beliefs Christians hold as true. This is a more architectonic project to be found, for example, not in the individual questions of the *Summa*, but in its overall construction as Aquinas moves from God to questions of Trinity, to creation, to a focus on human beings, their virtues and vices, to their redemption through grace, the theological virtues and their relationship to the other virtues, finally to the specifics of redemption in the incarnation and the sacramental life of the church.

Underlying this overall construction is the connection between belief in the Trinity, the Trinitarian processions and their extensions into the created order, the divine missions of the Son (incarnation) and the Spirit (grace). We can see current reflections of this process in the work of current theologians seeking connections between the doctrine of the Trinity and incarnation, creation, church, the moral life, and so on.³¹ Given the explosion of scholarship today and the breadth of material needed to be dealt with, it is doubtful that any one theologian would be able to achieve at the level of our times what Aquinas achieved at the level of his times. Even the task of systematics is inevitably collaborative.

While the goal of such a project is to demonstrate the coherence of Christian faith, at least internally, such coherence does not establish the truth of the beliefs involved.³² Incoherence establishes dissonance and falsehood, but things could be relatively coherent and still false. To seek to demonstrate truth through coherence is to invert the relationship between doctrines and systematics. Doctrines are held as true not because of their coherence but because of a complex set of judgments of truth—what God reveals is true; these doctrines have been revealed by God, through the mediation of the Christian tradition and the authority of the church; these judgments concur with my foundational commitments to religious conversion mediated to me by that same church; I hold these doctrines as true. Systematics proceeds on the basis of this affirmation of truth. This is not just a theological observation, but also in some sense a psychological norm. As Augustine regularly noted, “Unless you believe, you will not understand.” Without the conviction of faith, doctrines appear more like nonsense and unworthy of investigation. In the conviction of

31. See, for example, Anne Hunt, *Trinity: Nexus of the Mysteries of Christian Faith* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2005).

32. For example, Wolfhart Pannenberg places great stress on the question of the coherence of Christian faith.

faith one is willing to spend the time to seek “persistently, piously and soberly” for that limited understanding that systematics might offer us.

Communications

Of its very nature systematics is a technical task. It is not content with a merely descriptive approach but seeks explanatory knowledge, limited but real, through analogies and the interconnection of different beliefs. We have noted previously the different realms of meaning and systematics tends to find expression in a theoretic control of meaning (such as metaphysics), or perhaps more securely in interiority, where one’s basic terms and relations are grounded in an interiorly differentiated consciousness. Neither of these realms may be readily accessible to the proverbial person on the street. A further theological task is then to be found in the specialty of *communications*. This involves the transposition of meaning from the technical language of systematic theology into the commonsense language of a particular culture. Such a task requires an attentiveness to and creativity within the interpersonal, symbolic, and artistic carriers of meaning that effectively mediate this form of communication. This specialty takes theology out of the realm of the academy and into the concerns of pastoral care, preaching, catechesis, and community building in the life of the church. It marks a return to the lived experience of the church from which all theology must emerge.

Of course, there is always the temptation to short-circuit the process in an attempt to move directly into communications from various other components in a theological task. We noted earlier the criticism often made of critical historical methods that they are very good at telling us what the text meant in its original historical

context, but not as good at telling us what the text means for us today. It is often tempting to think that the outcomes of earlier phases must have some immediate applicability to the contemporary life of the church. However, this temptation has inherent difficulties. Often as not it is an attempt to bypass the intermediary normative phase of theology, creating unnecessary tensions between the work of positive scholarship in the first phase and the claims of the tradition mediated in the normative phase. This was very evident in the first quest for the historical Jesus, which pitted the Jesus of history against the Christ of faith, using historical outcomes in an attempt to rid the church of the dogmatic figure of Christ.³³ We can now look back at this and recognize the necessity of sound dialectics and foundations to address these outcomes prior to their communication to the church. In this normative phase the theologian takes on responsibility for handing on the tradition in all its fullness and depth, its variety and range, in a way which communicates divine meanings and values into the concrete circumstances of people's lives, in all their social and cultural complexity.

Of course, there is no automated process by which such a transposition can be undertaken. Often, it is a topic taken up in missiology, under the heading of enculturation, but within contemporary culture with its rapidly changing cultural assumptions and the growing impact of globalization, the task of such a transposition is ongoing, never complete and always subject to possible revision. New and creative expressions of the faith are needed to communicate the divine meanings and values carried in revelation; however, each such attempt carries a rightful anxiety that this new expression faithfully captures the divine intent. In the face of this anxiety, some would seek refuge in past formulations and

33. See the classical work, Albert Schweitzer, *The Quest of the Historical Jesus* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2001).

pious practices scorning attempts at “innovation,” but in the end the outcome of such an approach is to make faith look quaint and somewhat out of touch with the present situation. In the very attempt at being faithful, a different message is conveyed: to be faithful to God means living in the past, not the present. In seeking to avoid risk, they create their own set of risks: “If you make a mistake, you get up and go forward: that is the way. Those who do not walk in order not to err, make a more serious mistake.”³⁴

Conclusion: Theology as a Collaborative Project

Any academic enterprise is of necessity a collaborative cultural project. Scholars organize conferences to share ideas, they publish in peer-reviewed journals in order to communicate their work, they collaborate with colleagues in designing curricula for their students, and so on. In all of these labors, a process of self-correction operates within the discipline. The most egregious errors are weeded out: sources overlooked or misquoted, logical errors in theological reasoning, and exaggerated or unbalanced claims. This type of self-correcting process is present in all academic disciplines, including theology. In many disciplines, particularly those with minimal value-dimensions (such as mathematics or physics), this self-correcting process is enough to ensure that over time significant progress is made, error is eliminated, and new horizons for research and study can build on what has been securely established in the past.

Once value elements become integral to the discipline as a whole, be it the human meanings and values that fall under the aegis of the human sciences, or the divine meanings and values proper to theological disciplines, things become more complicated. The

34. From a homily of Pope Francis, 8 May 2013 for Mass in the Chapel of the *Domus Sanctae Marthae* residence in the Vatican, accessed August 7, 2015, <http://www.catholicismusa.com/christians-are-people-of-bridges-not-walls-seek-victims-of-idolatry-and-worldliness/>.

discipline automatically becomes more conflictual as the impact of the presence or absence of religious, moral, intellectual, and psychic conversions becomes more prominent. Without a method that thematizes conflict and points toward its resolution, these disciplines become fragmented into approaches with different methodologies leading to diverse, often opposed conclusions. Under such circumstances, the idea that a discipline might make progress becomes more difficult to maintain; debates are often at cross-purposes and what some regard as an advance, others reject as a retrograde step. Genuine progress, if it is acknowledged at all, is more haphazard and fragmentary and so ever precarious.

Is this then the fate of theology for the future? Can it no longer be a discipline which can securely build on the past, but must ever start anew to rebuild itself from scratch, reproducing all the debates of the past, following up all the previous dead ends, lest there be something there worth retrieving? One of the advantages of the method described above and enunciated by Bernard Lonergan is that it thematizes such conflict in the functional specialty of dialectics and finds some resolution through the specialty of foundations grounded in conversion. However, in order to implement such a proposal, a deeper sense of collaboration needs to emerge, more than the types of collaboration we outlined above. What is needed is a *methodological* collaboration which goes beyond a mere *de facto* resignation to a theological pluralism toward a more unified vision of theology as a collaborative project based on eight distinct but intimately related functional specialties each of which makes its own vital contribution to the theological task of mediating the past into the present for the sake of the future. Our hope is that the present work acts as an invitation to such a collaborative vision.

